

ness a similar transition Our natural biological condition might in the future be constituted of non-biological and technical components. The radical cybernetic evolution that is taking-off may substantially reengineer our body and extend our lifespan to a biologically immortal state. The prognosis of such changes will in the near future. It might just be like the typewriter phenomenon; replaced by new technology and human through cybernetics transcends to biologically immortal cyborgs.

Death of Humanity and Freedom

Nanotechnology is often referred to as the Fourth Horseman of Transhumanism, with Synthetic Biology, Artificial Intelligence and Virtual Reality, making up the other three. There are many directions, we can go with these four horsemen, but there is a great danger of Nanotechnology being hijacked and its development and application being restricted to the Military and Pharmaceutical Companies. Nanotechnology can be misused to take away our freedom of choice in just about everything, from the food we eat to the medical treatment we want.

Nanotechnology can take away our humanity. Inexpensive, invisible, powerful devices threaten freedom and privacy if they fall into the wrong hands. A totalitarian regime could use nanodevices to coerce its citizens. In the short term, it could monitor them pervasively with tiny sensors or threaten them with nanoweapons. In the long-term, modifying the populace with nanosurgery or even using nanobots to transform the genes of future citizens is not inconceivable. With nanodevices to do the work, large sectors of the population could be selectively destroyed, and intervention by other nations could be discouraged by threats based on expertise in nanotechnology.

A unifying theme in this undercurrent of anxiety toward technology is the belief that certain aspects of the human condition are fixed, inherent, or “natural”. According to this perspective, trying to change the constants that have shaped human experience, trying to go beyond the boundaries said to be drawn by nature, is to commit an immoral act. The act is immoral because it changes the conditions that made us human and thus risks bringing our humanity to an end. For example, human beings have never before had the power to change the genetic basis of their thoughts and abilities. This limitation has been an inherent part of what it means to be human.

If the visions of the nanotechnologists come to pass, the impact on society would likely be even more profound than the changes wrought by previous advances in technology. Strange and alien notions like biotech agriculture, in vitro fertilization, cloning, hand-held computers, and the Internet would pale